The Crying Game
Director: Neil Jordan
©: Palace (Soldier's Wife) Ltd,
Nippon Film Development & Finance,
Palace Productions, Eurotrustees
Production Company: Channel Four
With the participation of: British Screen
Executive Producer: Nik Powell
Producer: Stephen Woolley
Co-producer: Elizabeth Karlsen
Associate Producer: Paul Cowan
Production Manager (Ireland): Gemma Fallon
Production Co-ordinators: Fran Triefus,
Fiona Traynor
Production Accountants: Pat Isherwood,
Sarah Lucraft
Post-production Accountant: Michael Garland
Location Manager: Terry Blyther
Location Manager (Re-shoot): Gilly Case
Location Manager (Ireland): Martin O'Malley
Location Assistant: Scott Rowlatt
Post-production Supervisor: Amanda Posey
Mr Woolley's Assistant: Peter Ogunsalu
Producer's Assistants: Polly Withers, Polly Leys
Production Runner: Andrew Zein
Floor Runner: Samantha Plaisted
Post-production Runner: Sally Hodges
Runners/Drivers: Sara Desmond, Cheryl Willcocks
1st Assistant Director: Redmond Morris
2nd Assistant Directors: Melvin Lind,
Jonathan Karlsen
2nd Assistant Director (Ireland): Seamus Collins
3rd Assistant Director (Ireland): Robert Quinn
Director's Assistant: Brenda Rawn
Script Supervisor: Diana Dill
Casting Director: Susie Figgis
Casting Assistant: Liora Reich
Screenplay: Neil Jordan
Director of Photography: Ian Wilson
Camera Operator: Ian Wilson
Focus Puller: Kenny Byrne
Clapper Loader: Brendan Glavin
Camera Trainee: Dan Zeff
Gaffer: Norman Smith
Rigging Gaffer: Vincent Clarke
Best Boy: Dave Escoffrey
Electricians: Ricky Pattenden, Gary Colkett,
Paul Wood
Electricians (Irish Unit): Louis Conroy,
Noel Cullen, Terry Mulligan
Camera Grip: Gary Hutchings
Stills Photography: Tom Hilton
Special Effects Supervisor: Peter Hutchinson
Editor: Kant Pan
Assistant Editor: Martyn Robinson
2nd Assistant Editor: Victoria Boydell
Production Designer: Jim Clay
Art Director: Chris Seagers
Assistant Art Director: Paul Ghirardani
Art Department Runner: Jane Henwood
Set Decorator: Martin Childs
Production Buyer: Celia Bobak
Prop Master: Micky Bacon
Chargehand Standby Props: Eddie Francis,
Paul Bradburn
Dressing Prop/Storeman: Rodney Pincott
Dressing Prop: Brian Aldridge
Dressing Prop (Irish Unit): Peter Gallagher
Construction Manager: Dave Allen
Construction Manager (Irish Unit): John Lamon
Painter (Irish Unit): Bobby Scott
Carpenter (Irish Unit): Brian Bassett
Stagehand (Irish Unit): James O'Meara

Fear of the Dark: Lola Young on Race, Gender and Sexuality in Cinema

The Crying Game

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

The Crying Game, an unusual story of an IRA operative who seeks out and falls for the 'widow' of a British squaddie he helped to kidnap remains Jordan's best known and most widely celebrated work, and won him an Oscar for Best Original Screenplay. It is therefore ironic to note that the film almost wasn't made. No backers could be found for it in either the United States or Ireland because the plot, which involved an interracial love story between a Black English transsexual and an Irish republican gunman, was considered far too taboo. British production companies were equally reluctant to take the film unless serious changes were made. Jordan, however, had been working on this scenario, which he originally called *The Soldier's Wife* (it was Stanley Kubrick who suggested the title change, warning Jordan that audiences would otherwise mistake it for a war movie), since he completed *Angel* [1982] and he was loath to change anything now that he had developed it to his satisfaction.

Stephen Woolley, the former head of Palace Pictures and Jordan's long-time producer, finally patched together a £2.3m budget from four sources: British Screen; Channel 4; Eurotrustees; and a Japanese distribution company, Nippon Development & Finance. The money was, however, barely adequate for a film of this scope and shooting began before all the finance was in place. Palace Pictures was also close to folding (and would do so before *The Crying Game* was released); on the third day of filming, the production was almost shut down and the original cinematographer quit. In order to keep the wheels moving, Woolley had to resort to using his own credit cards and raiding the tills at his London cinema, The Scala. As tense as the shoot was, however, the cast and crew soldiered on as there was a strong sense that the film was going to be something special.

The Crying Game was not an overnight success. On the contrary, it was the very definition of a sleeper hit. The film was refused entry at Cannes and was released in Ireland and the UK with little fanfare. The early notices in Ireland were positive, but the British reviews were mixed and in a case of very bad timing, the release coincided with a new IRA offensive in England. Most discussions of the film therefore centred on its politics, which nobody seemed able to agree upon (the film was alternatively accused of being pro- and anti-IRA). Moreover, critics were uncertain of how to review a movie that seemed to rely so heavily on a twist revealed halfway through the narrative. The film seemed destined to cause a brief stir, as all films about the IRA do, and then fade into relative obscurity. Woolley's company Palace was wound down after going into receivership, while Jordan returned to writing fiction and published his third novel, *Sunrise with Sea Monster* (1994), as he was certain his film career was over. The US release changed all of that. Miramax, which was then a fledgling company, had refused to help fund *The Crying Game* but quickly agreed to distribute it after Harvey Weinstein saw the finished version. In what seems like a gimmick more suited to a schlocky 1950s thriller, the Miramax advertising campaign asked both critics and viewers not to reveal the key plot twist. The US critics were less concerned with politics and played along, and audiences seemed willing to overlook Jordan's use of cricketing metaphors (usually the kiss of death for a British film in America).

Costume Designer: Sandy Powell
Wardrobe Supervisors: Paul Minter, Clare Spragge
Wardrobe Assistant (Irish Unit): Wendy Asher
Chief Make-up Artist: Morag Ross
Assistant to Make-up Artist: Miri Ben-Shlomo
Prosthetics: Daniel Parker
Chief Hairdresser: Gerry Jones
Titles: Optical Partnership
Music/Orchestrations: Anne Dudley, Boy George
Music Performed by:
The Pro Arte Orchestra of London
Orchestra Contractor: Colin Sheen
Music Recording Mixer: Roger Dudley
Sound Recording: Colin Nicolson
Sound Trainee: Damiano Vukotic
Boom Operator: Tony Cook
Re-recording Mixers: Robin O'Donoghue, Dominic Lester
Supervising Sound Editor: Eddy Joseph
Assistant Sound Editor: Leonard Green
Dialogue Editor: Rick Dunford
Footsteps Editor: Victor Nunes
Stunt Co-ordinator: Clive Curtis
Stunt Drivers: Del Baker, Wayne Michaels, Valentino Musetti
Stunt Doubles: Helen Caldwell, Abbi Collins, Elaine Ford
Stand-ins: Steve Morphew, Marilyn Took
Electrician's Driver: Martin Redrup
Unit Drivers: Terry English, Gerry Floyd
Unit Nurse: Millstream Nursing, Eileen Conroy
Fairground Supervisors (Irish Unit): Bernard McCormack, Angela Morrison, Frederick Elmes
Publicity: Phil Symes, Michelle Sewell, Rogers & Cowan
Studios: Lee International Studios, Shepperton Studios
Cast:
Forest Whitaker *(Jody)*
Miranda Richardson *(Jude)*
Stephen Rea *(Fergus)*
Adrian Dunbar *(Maguire)*
Breffni McKenna *(Tinker)*
Joe Savino *(Eddie)*
Birdy Sweeney *(Tommy)*
Jaye Davidson *(Dil)*
Andrée Bernard *(Jane)*
Jim Broadbent *(Col)*
Ralph Brown *(Dave)*
Tony Slattery *(Deveroux)*
Jack Carr *(Franknum)*
Josephine White, Shar Campbell *(bar performers)*
Brian Coleman *(judge)*
Ray De-Haan, David Cronnelly *(security men)*
UK-Japan 1992©
112 mins
Digital

The film soon began generating considerable word of mouth. It was moved from art-house theatres into mainstream cinemas and as many as 1,000 prints were finally in circulation. Miramax also began campaigning for the film to be considered at the 1993 Academy Awards. It was eventually nominated in six categories, including Best Picture for Woolley, Best Director and Best Original Screenplay for Jordan, Best Actor for Stephen Rea, Best Supporting Actor for Jaye Davidson (a nomination that gave away the film's twist by revealing the actor playing Dil to be a man) and Best Editing for Kant Pan. Although only Jordan's screenplay finally won, the nominations further increased interest in the film, which went on to gross more than $60m and, in the process, helped establish Miramax as a major player in US film and revived the fortunes of both Jordan and Woolley.

Jordan richly deserved his Oscar for *The Crying Game*. His screenplay offers a masterclass in structure and narrative construction. Although some critics complained that the film is divided into two distinct halves (some also said of variable quality), it is entirely of a piece. Indeed, everything that happens in the second half of the film, in which Fergus arrives in London to find Dil, is set up during the first half of the film, in which Fergus kidnaps and befriends Jody in Ireland. From the opening moments, during which we hear Percy Sledge sing 'When a Man Loves a Woman', and from the first lines of dialogue (Jody saying: 'Now that's cricket, hon,' or 'Never pissed holding a girl's hand, Jude.'), Jordan established a tone of irony and double meaning. It is so subtly done, however, that it is only upon subsequent viewings that his sly game becomes apparent.

Of course, it is not the screenplay alone that has made the film a modern classic. Credit must also go to the cast. Jordan's films have generally been very well acted but the ensemble in *The Crying Game* is almost note perfect. Rea, Davidson and Miranda Richardson could not be better, Forest Whitaker's screen presence and intelligence more than make up for his wavering accent and smaller roles by Adrian Dunbar, Ralph Brown and Jim Broadbent have just the right amount of menace and ambiguity. Credit must also go to Jordan's direction; the film's noirish visuals, courtesy of replacement cinematographer Ian Wilson; and Kant Pan's tight editing. *The Crying Game* is a masterpiece and, like all masterpieces, it is a work you can revisit in the knowledge that you will find something new each time – even if you already know the twist.

Brian Hoyle, extract from *The Crying Game* DVD/Blu-ray booklet essay (BFI, 2017)

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